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Applying the Pressure: Exploring How Instructor Strictness Impacts Students' Individual Classroom Experiences

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ABSTARCT

Students tend to think negatively of strict (i.e., inflexible) instructors. However, strictness as an instructional variable is not theoretically positioned as positive or negative; its impact likely varies depending on the person. To investigate this idea, the current study thematically analyzed narratives from 457 students about their interactions with strict instructors. Three themes were identified from a clustering of 8 sub-themes reflecting a wide range of outcomes in the wake of perceived strict behavior: (1) Mindset and Motivation, (2) Affective Responses, and (3) Relational Distance. Although strictness is generally viewed as an undesirable instructor behavior, its actual influence appeared to be mixed. Moreover, responses highlighted how perceptions of strictness may have an indirect impact on students' actual learning.

KEYWORDS

Engagement; inflexibility; interest; mindset; strictness

College classrooms rely on a variety of rules, policies, and norms – some created by instructors and some mandated by institutions – intended to reduce students' uncertainty and provide structure to promote academic success (Fuentes, Zelaya, and Madsen 2021; Jenkins, Bugeja, and Barber 2014; Thompson 2007). Whether these governing messages are expressed in a syllabus or established as part of an instructor's normative expectations for a classroom setting, students' experiences are no doubt influenced by both the rules, policies, and norms they are expected to follow and the ways in which they are communicated (Frey, Moore, and Dragojevic 2021; Moore and Richards 2019; Paulsel and Chory-Assad 2004; Tatum, Olson, and Frey 2018). Ultimately, students' perceptions of these messages are likely shaped by the way instructors actually enforce them. Some instructors might never face the need for enforcement because their students clearly follow their rules, some might simply choose not to enforce policies at all, and some might maintain rigorous adherence to policies and procedures. One potential framework for understanding how these differing policy enforcement strategies are enacted in classroom instruction is the exploration of *instructor strictness*.

Strictness is "the perceived inflexibility of an instructor based on their unwavering adherence to instructional policies and procedures" (Tatum and Frey 2021). Essentially, instructor strictness deals with how rigidly or loosely an instructor adheres to policies, procedures, and/or norms. Much of what scholars know about strictness originally stems from Wubbels, Créton, and Hooymayers (1985) Questionnaire on Teacher Interaction (QTI). The QTI contains a mixture of 6 high-inference and low-inference items (e.g., this teacher's standards are very high; we have to be silent in this teacher's class) that operationalize the construct alongside a variety of other dimensions of instructor interpersonal behavior (e.g., leadership, freedom, helpfulness, uncertainty). However, Frey and Tatum (2022) extended this thinking from a communicative perspective. Open-ended responses from students indicated that instructors perceived as strict are known to closely monitor behavior, inflexibly enforce both explicit and implicit policies, and hold high standards for students' behavior, knowledge, and performance. For example, study narratives revealed that strict instructors graded assignments harshly, assigned a heavy workload over short time periods, banned students' technologies (e.g., phones, laptops), did not allow students to eat in class or leave to use the bathroom, resolutely used a single teaching method (e.g., lecture), required students to complete work in very specific ways, called students out for not following policies, spoke to students sternly, or did not make

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themselves available for help outside of instructional time, to name a few. In their development of a scale to measure this underexplored construct, Frey and Tatum forwarded three general patterns of perceived strictness: evaluative, regulatory, and interactive.

Evaluative strictness refers to the enforcement of rules, policies, or practices dealing with the direct assessment of students' content knowledge or ability to complete instructional objectives (e.g., grading harshness, curving grades). *Regulatory* strictness refers to the way instructors use policies and procedures to manage the classroom and facilitate ideal conditions for student learning and growth (e.g., deadlines, technology policies). *Interactive* strictness refers to the way instructors interpersonally communicate about their policies and procedures to students both within and outside the classroom (e.g., availability, rudeness). Each type of strictness has been positively associated with perceptions of strictness and admonishing behavior (described in Wubbels, Créton, and Hooymayers (1985) QTI through specific behaviors like getting angry, expressing irritation, correcting, and punishing students), students' perceptions of instructors' cognitive flexibility, and theoretically similar instructional styles (Frey 2023). Conversely, each pattern has been significantly, negatively related to perceived instructor caring. The collective qualitative and quantitative evidence suggests that students view Frey and Tatum (2022) operationalizations of strictness negatively.

Yet, these findings clash with the original conceptualization of the construct, where strict instructor behavior is not inherently positive or negative. In fact, there may be conditions whereby an instructor's inflexible behavior actually functions to motivate or positively impact students. For example, Kendall and Schussler (2013) argued that strictness may sometimes be necessary for ensuring that students behave amicably in large classrooms or making sure that rules are applied equally to all students. It may be that if a student perceives the purpose of an instructor's inflexibility is to ultimately benefit them (i.e., there is a good reason this rule is in place), they will evaluate the behavior positively. Nonetheless, the idea that a strict instructor can have a constructive impact on students' instructional experiences is purely theoretical. The goal of this research is to make sense of these competing ideas by qualitatively analyzing how students' actual experiences with strictness affected them within the classroom. In doing so, we hope to gain a more nuanced understanding of the outcomes students regularly associate with strict instruction:

RQ: How does perceived instructor strictness impact students' experiences in a classroom setting?

Methods

Participants and procedures

Participants included 457 undergraduate students enrolled in communication courses at a large, Southern institution (180 men, 39.39%; 276 women, 60.39%, 1 did not report, 0.22%). Participants ranged in age from 18 to 54 ($M = 19.72$, $SD = 2.86$), with 187 first-year students (40.92%), 59 sophomores (12/91%), 125 juniors (27.35%), 85 seniors (18.60%), and 1 fifth-year senior or beyond (0.22%). Students identified as White/Caucasian ($n = 358$; 78.34%), Black or African American ($n = 34$; 7.44%), Asian or Pacific Islander ($n = 37$; 8.10%), Hispanic or Latino/Latina ($n = 17$; 3.72%), Native American or American Indian ($n = 1$; 0.22%), and Other ($n = 10$; 2.19%).

The present data were collected as part of a larger study evaluating how strictness functions in the collegiate classroom. Students were recruited *via* a research participation system. After self-selecting to participate, students were redirected to an online survey hosted by Qualtrics. Students were informed that those who completed the survey would earn minimal course credit (1% of their total grade), and those choosing not to take part would be provided with an alternate assignment worth up to the same amount of credit. Following consent, students were provided with the definition of instructor strictness proposed by Tatum and Frey (2021) and then prompted to provide written responses to several open-ended questions designed to isolate their specific experiences with strict instructors (e.g., "Tell me a story about when an instructor during college was strict"). The data for this study are drawn from responses to two questions: (1) When instructors are strict, how does this affect your ability to learn? and (2) How does an instructor being strict affect your classroom experience? No information was collected about the instructor of reference in the students' responses to protect their anonymity.

Thematic analysis

Braun and Clarke (2006) approach to qualitative thematic analysis and interpretation was used to explore students' responses. They define a thematic analysis as "a method for identifying, analysing, and reporting patterns (themes) within data" (p. 79). From their perspective, thematic analysis is flexible and can function as a method used to reflect reality or a method that attempts to uncover what constitutes reality. Thus, we felt it was an appropriate method for us to uncover the ways in which strictness may uniquely function

across a range of student experiences. Their approach includes six steps: (1) familiarizing oneself with the data, (2) generating initial codes, (3) looking for themes, (4) evaluating themes, (5) defining and naming themes, and (6) producing the report.

To start, three raters (two Caucasian men and one Caucasian woman, all with teaching experience in secondary education) read the data individually, allowing for personal and holistic interpretations. No outside or preexisting categorization scheme was used for analysis apart from our own understanding of instructional communication literature. Second, after familiarizing ourselves with the data, we met on several occasions to compare our initial observations. We discussed similarities and differences among the responses, including whether we felt the data were accurately reflecting the communication-specific definition of instructor strictness provided to participants before they completed the open-ended questions. Third, we reflected on the key themes and concepts that we felt were present within the data. Following the advice of Lincoln and Guba (1985), we read the data together line by line to generate categories based on their surface-level characteristics. All initial themes were recorded in an initial codebook. Fourth, we met several times to revise, modify, or adjust categories based on our evolving understandings of the data. This included discussing new categories for responses that did not fall within the initial themes. As this process occurred, the codebook was revised appropriately. Fifth, the revised concepts, themes, and markers from the surface-level categories were combined to broadly reflect themes across the entire data set. We met on several occasions and discussed the themes in detail until we reached an agreement that the themes accurately reflected students' original narratives. The codebook was revised again accordingly[1]. The sixth step is presented below in the form of our final themes and relevant examples.

To evaluate intercoder reliability, the three coders independently rated 25% of the dataset. Krippendorff's (2004) α with bootstrapped confidence intervals was used to assess agreement between the raters. The procedure was conducted using the KALPHA macro for SPSS (Hayes and Krippendorff 2007). The resulting interrater reliability coefficient was acceptable (K_α = .83).

Results

Three themes were identified from a clustering of 8 sub-themes that best defined the outcomes students associated with strict instruction: (1) Mindset and Motivation, (2) Affective Responses, and (3) Relational Distance. Students often described their experiences with strict instruction in terms of its impact on their general disposition and attitude toward the classroom experience. For other students, perceived instructor strictness triggered several different affective responses, including increased feelings of pressure, anxiety, stress, and fear. Finally, some students explained that strictness resulted in increased relational distance with either the instructor or their peers. To make better sense of the overall themes, we describe each of the subthemes in the next section.

Mindset and motivation

The theme of mindset and motivation dealt primarily with the ways students changed their attitudes to be more or less persistent and intense in their educational pursuits. The three sub-themes within this theme were shifts in grade orientation, improved study habits, and enhanced focus.

Shifts in grade orientation

The sub-theme of shifts in grade orientation involved students changing their mindsets from wanting to commit new knowledge to memory or successfully apply it in practical scenarios to simply completing assigned work so they could successfully move through the course. Larry, a 20-year-old, White, male junior wrote: "For me, when instructors are strict, I tend to focus more on getting a good grade in the class instead of actually learning and retaining the material." Ruby, an 18-year-old, African American, female sophomore articulated this same idea: "It kind of makes me focus on the grades more than learning." Lucy, a 20-year-old, White, female junior articulated additional details about how this shift influences her ability to complete course assignments:

> If there are times where I am rushing to get the assignment finished and they don't allow late work or extensions, I will just do the bare minimum and worry about making the bad grade up in another assignment rather than trying to get the assignment done right and understand what it is I am doing.

Improved study habits

The subtheme of improved study habits reflects the first instance of potentially helpful and proactive student responses following perceived strict behavior. In this case, strictness motivated students to adopt new habits or study skills that they felt ultimately benefited their learning. In other words, students felt the instructor's

inflexibility put them in a better position to succeed. Brittany, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student stated: "It helps push me to get my work done quicker and have better time management." Carla, a 20-year-old, White, female, junior said: "I knew there was no easy way out and I actually needed to know every bit of the material. I would study for these exams for 20+ hours and I ended up receiving an A in the class." Another student, Tony, an 18-year-old, African American, male, first-year student reflected that it "Kinda makes it better because they give no room for error or cheating or any type of reference, so you are forced to learn the material and study." So, while some students clearly felt that strict instruction inhibited their desire to study, learn content, or complete assignments, some students contrarily felt that strictness motivated them to learn more and perform better.

Enhanced focus

The sub-theme of enhanced focus reflects how many students felt that perceived strict behavior helped them succeed by forcing them into a mindset of hard work or by reducing the prevalence of distractions. Darwin, an 18-year-old, Hispanic, male, first-year student stated: "My ability to learn actually somewhat increases when instructors are strict…Overall, I also tend to focus more and work a bit harder when the teacher is strict." Similarly, Jody, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student claimed: "I think that I kept me focused because I knew that I could not mess around in the class. I think it allowed me to focus on learning." Contrary to some of the other categories, responses within this theme were also often other-focused; they tended to reflect how the student benefited from an instructor enforcing their policies for others' behavior. To illustrate, Max, a 20-year-old, White, male junior stated: "I find that it can be distracting when many students are being disruptive and the instructor doesn't say anything. When the instructor is strict on these policies it can make the classroom experience much better." Alex, a 19-year-old, White, male, first-year student also showcased how an instructor's inflexible behavior toward others in the class created a positive environment:

> It makes me get my work done better if they are strict in a way that they don't let people mess around in their class. I have no problem with teachers that don't tolerate students that act up during class.

Clearly, several students identified strictness as a catalyst for working more diligently to achieve their academic goals.

Affective responses

The theme of affective responses reflected the ways students emotionally reacted to their instructor's inflexible behavior. The three sub-themes within this theme were increased pressure, increased stress/anxiety, and intimidation.

Increased pressure

As a result of strictness, some students felt increased pressure to complete their work, impress the instructor, or avoid making mistakes. Carey, a 29-year-old, Bi-racial, male junior stated: "I feel the pressure of being called on in class to answer a question. So to not look stupid in class, I do all the work prior to the class, which takes up a lot of time." Contrarily, Shepherd, a 22-year-old, White, male, senior reiterated the pressure that comes from anticipating how a strict instructor might act in the future:

> I believe it applies more pressure on yourself. Not only does it apply pressure in the sense of needing to learn the material and study more, but it also applies pressure on you to do well in the class to avoid confrontation or being looked down upon.

Vivian, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student also said: "For me personally, I believe it puts a lot of pressure on me to be perfect. Its hard to learn and improve knowing you can't make mistakes without getting reprimanded." Students appeared to collectively feel extra pressure in the wake of strictness, although the pressure itself impacted them in unique ways.

Increased stress/anxiety

The theme of increased stress/anxiety describes students' internalized tension as a result of their instructor's strict behavior. Andrea, a 21-year-old, White, female junior said: "It usually stresses me out to the point I am more worried about their restrictions than the actual course work." Brenda, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student repeated this sentiment:

> It gives me super high anxiety. I feel as though I can't mess up and I have to be extremely cookie cutter and perfect. I can't try to think out of the box because I might end up being wrong.

Ginny, an 18-year-old, Asian, female, first-year student also recalled how she felt when her instructors were strict: "I get extremely anxious and stressed because I feel like any small mistake will cost my

grade. Eventually not being able to enjoy what I learn and fully understand what I'm learning."

Intimidation

The theme of intimidation was defined by students feeling scared of the instructor's actions, clearly disliking the experience of being in class, or not looking forward to attending, interacting, or participating. Ella, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student, stated:

> Strict teachers make for very unpleasant classroom experiences. I get very intimidated by them, nervous, anxious, and just flat out scared to be in the same room as them…so I will typically just stay quiet and not contribute to any class discussions.

Hassan, an 18-year-old, Arab, male, first-year student illustrated this idea on a broader, communal level: "The collective classroom experience is ruined, there is no positive energy in the room, everyone is just slaving away trying their absolute hardest to meet the unnecessarily harsh demands of the teacher." Students were quick to point out that the intimidation was also signified by a lack of participation. For example, Haley, a 20-year-old, White, female, junior said: "I feel like a strict professor makes the classroom experience more tense. I am more scared of being called on or pointed out by strict professors, and generally feel less open to asking questions or sharing my beliefs." The responses comprised by this theme paint a picture of a disciplinary classroom, where students might remain engaged with course content but less likely to share their knowledge or interact.

Relational distance

The theme of relational distance dealt with how strictness impacted students' interpersonal connections with their instructor and their peers. The two sub-themes within this theme were *decreased connectedness* and *deterrence from help-seeking*.

Decreased connectedness

Decreased connectedness was reflected in responses where a student experienced less rapport and connection with either their instructor or their classmates based on the instructor's strict behavior. Maria, a 23-year-old, Hispanic, female senior remarked: "This affects my relationship with my professor and creates a negative connection to the classroom experience." A response from Micki, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student again reflected the nuance of the effects of strictness: "…it doesn't affect my classroom experience much, but does affect my relationship with the instructor." Strictness did not appear to inhibit Micki's ability to learn or enjoy herself in the classroom, but it did impact the level of connection she felt with the instructor. Contrarily, Ryan, an 18-year-old, White, male sophomore said: "It decreases my ability to learn because I do not feel like we are on the same team. A professor and student relationship should go both ways, not just one person barking orders at the other." From Ryan's perspective, a positive relationship was a necessary precursor to learning, and the instructor's strict behavior did not allow this to occur. Phoebe, a 19-year-old, Asian, female, junior also explained that "It makes it hard to meet you classmates and interact with them".

Deterrence from help-seeking

Many students felt that strict instruction made it difficult to seek help when it was needed. Connie, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student stated: "Having a strict instructor makes it more difficult to go to them if you have questions in fear that they won't help you or make adjustments on due dates if needed." Mollie, an 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student reiterated this thinking: "I would say an instructor being strict negatively affects my classroom experience because I feel like I cannot talk to that instructor or get help from them if I need it." Mac, an 18-year-old, White, male, first-year student also said: "I think it makes me nervous to ask questions, which means I won't always seek the help I need with classwork, making it significantly harder to learn the topics that work covers." For some students, an instructor's inflexible adherence to their rules and procedures made them less likely to ask for clarity or guidance when it was needed to achieve their goals.

Discussion

Scholarship has only scratched the surface of systematically investigating how rules, policies, and procedures are actually enforced in college classrooms (e.g., Flanigan et al. 2022). This study adds to the body of theoretical work examining classroom influence (e.g., compliance gaining, Burroughs 2007; justice, Paulsel and Chory-Assad 2004) through a unique lens: instructor strictness. Students were asked to provide written narratives about how strict instruction individually influenced their classroom experiences. The themes and sub-themes established during the thematic analysis have two important implications for

knowledge of strictness as an social science concept moving forward.

First, strictness produced a variety of outcomes, some that were beneficial to students' experiences and some that were detrimental. It also appeared that some sub-themes produced outcomes that varied across students. For example, whereas increased pressure may feel like an inherently negative outcome – and was perceived as such by some students – others utilized the increased pressure to their advantage. Nonetheless, the themes of intimidation, deterrence from help-seeking, shifts in grade orientation, increases in stress/anxiety, and decreased connectedness suggest that many students do not experience positive outcomes following strict instruction; although the original conceptualization is value-free in nature, many students view the concept of strictness as undesirable. Moreover, the responses do not provide insight into the conditions, factors, or traits that led some to view it as constructive.

Thus, we can only speculate as to why inflexibility was helpful for some but not for others. One explanation, as proposed by Frey and Tatum (2022), is that strict instructors are perceived positively when students know their instructor has their best interests at heart. If a student knows that an instructor is strict because he or she cares about them, then perhaps strictness can motivate students to study or enhance their focus. Another explanation lies in the nature of the students themselves. A student's response to strictness may be purely psychological based on individual traits like academic entitlement, grit, resilience, perspective-taking ability, or self-efficacy. Students who view themselves in specific ways may be shielded from experiencing strictness as a personal attack, instead internalizing it as a challenge to work harder or achieve more. In any case, the results present researchers with a roadmap for investigating strictness in the future by highlighting how it functions in unique and independent ways, similar to how researchers have approached the study of constructive and destructive aggression in classroom settings (e.g., Schrodt 2003).

Second, the themes suggest that strictness may not impact learning directly. Rather, the effects of strictness on learning may be conditional depending on a variety of other factors (Goodboy 2017). This is not to suggest that students' narratives overlooked learning; learning was mentioned often as an outcome of strict instruction. However, learning was generally framed as something that strictness impacted by way of other processes. Some of the narratives encompassed by the sub-themes highlight a few ways that this might take place. For example, strictness could impact learning *via* interest (e.g., "It also hinders the subject itself, making me less interested and not as eager to learn about it as I originally was;" Marlie, 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student), engagement (e.g., "I am going to be much less likely to engage in the classroom if an instructor is strict;" Jeremy, 20-year-old, White, male junior), motivation (e.g., "I don't want to fall behind in classes with strict instructors, so I find that I am more motivated for those classes;" Jenny, 21-year-old, Asian, female junior), or other emotional responses like frustration (e.g., "I sometimes become frustrated with the instructor because I feel as if they do not care about my well-being. This leads to me simply finishing the work, not actually learning it"; Sarah, 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student) and fear (e.g., "It makes me feel as if I cannot talk or collaborate with other students in the class because of the fear of being shut down by the teacher;" Meghan, 18-year-old, White, female, first-year student). Thus, how strictness actually impacts a student's classroom experience could largely depend on their psychological response to an instructor's communication.

From a theoretical perspective, the results bolster Frey and Tatum (2022) call for research that further investigates how policy enforcement strategies can impact students in differential ways. Practically, we hesitate to encourage instructors to adopt purely flexible and accommodative stances when it comes to their syllabi. Some students clearly appreciate having rigid and structured instructional experiences. However, instructors should be mindful that the way they discuss and enforce their policies can have a potentially harmful impact on students.

The main limitation to this study concerns differences in cultural expectations of strictness. The responses consisted overwhelming of White and female students, whereas researchers have suggested that students may have different expectations for classroom control and discipline across cultures. For example, Jiang et al. (2020) concluded that strict instruction was negatively related to Western students' motivational beliefs and positively related to motivational beliefs for Eastern students. They concluded that the power distance that characterizes Confucian heritage cultures results in a greater emphasize on obedience and compliance compared to Western societies, where individual differences in thinking and interest are valued; "Given the differences in social norms and cultural roots as discussed above, teacher strictness may be more acceptable to East Asian students because it meets their expectations and aligns with

the cultural and social values of Eastern societies" (p. 6). Essentially, depending on cultural expectations, strictness may be deemed acceptable by students (Biggs and Watkins 2001). A content analysis approach examining the frequency and magnitude of the identified themes in comparison to one another may generate important insight about the learning outcomes strict instruction affects most often.

Second, a small group of participants indicated that they have not yet had a strict collegiate instructor. Yet, because the research questions of interest focused on strictness in general, their responses were included in the analysis. We can conclude that most participants had prior experience with strict instructors, yet a few students reported on their idea of how strictness might influence them rather than actual experience. Likewise, the study does not include direct measures of learning, instead focusing on self-report narratives from students regarding their perceived learning and experiences. Students may not be able to accurately judge or rate their own learning, suggesting that more objective or observational methods of assessing learning in the wake of strictness may produce different outcomes (Hess, Smythe, and Communication 2001).

Finally, another limitation concerns the transferability of the results to other institutions. At the time of data collection, the COVID-19 pandemic had changed the landscape of higher education to be more inclusive of flexible and distanced learning options (Miller, Sellnow, and Strawser 2021). For the current study, data were collected during the Fall 2020 academic semester. At that time, several classes had been moved online, but many classes – particularly for first-year students, remained in-person. It remains to be seen whether the results change when students explicitly differentiate between their online or face-to-face courses or when responses are collected from institutions in geographically and culturally diverse locations.

Collectively, this research stresses the need for continued study of instructor strictness as an important and influential instructional variable. One additional avenue for research concerns the link between strictness and students' cultural expectations, with a specific focus on the way standard child rearing practices contribute to students' beliefs about instructor behaviors in a secondary education context. To illustrate, research routinely highlights how authoritative parents – who exhibit both controlling and caring behaviors with their children in the form of confrontive power– are generally associated with positive outcomes (Baumrind 2012). This parenting styles balances both confirmation of a child's identity and sets explicit standards for future behavior (Baumrind 2013). Other areas in need of exploration include the role of both student and instructor gender in perceptions of strictness (e.g., Jones and Dindia 2004), how strictness relates to individual student differences in cognitive control (i.e., neurodivergent students; Frey 2023; Snyder, Miyake, and Hankin 2015), and how strict instruction may constrain students' creative processes or critical thinking skills (e.g., Fredagsvik 2023). This important body of work will help scholars and practitioners develop a more comprehensive understanding of the way policy messaging and enforcement impact students' instructional experiences.

Note

[1]The final codebook is available at https://osf.io/nywuc/?view_only=21cd0ba43171419ba3162e1fb9f254ea.

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